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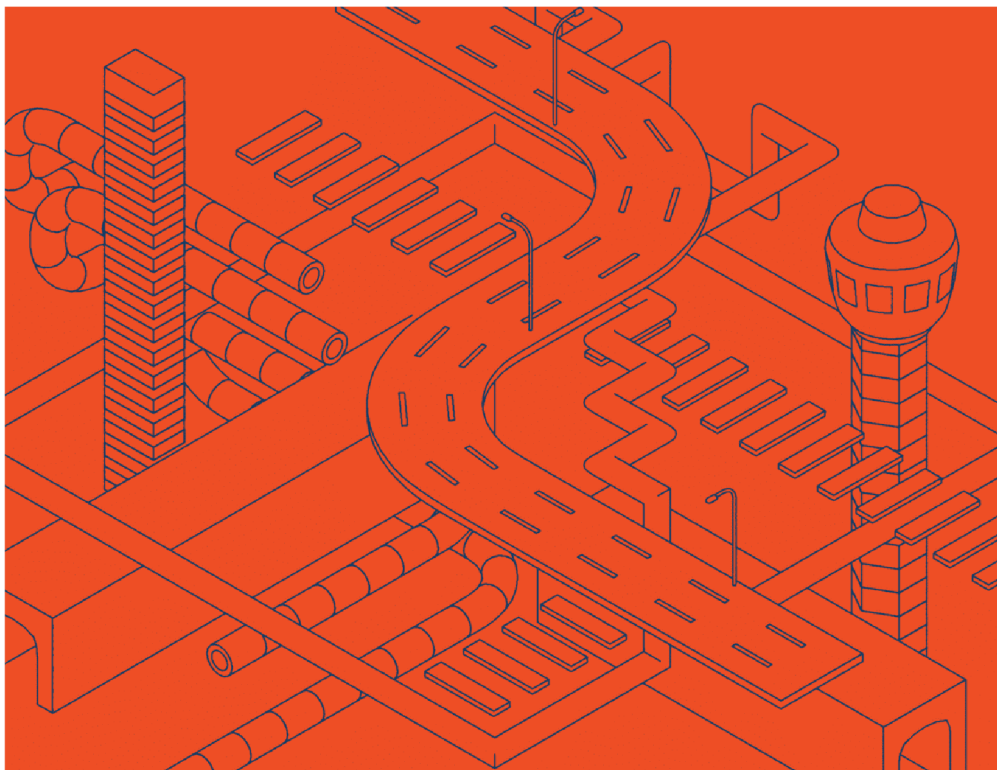
Planning Priorities for New Jersey's Next Governor

by Zoe Baldwin



For over a century, Regional Plan Association (RPA) has worked to improve the quality of life, environmental resilience, and economic vitality of the New Jersey–New York–Connecticut metropolitan region through planning, research and advocacy.

As a new Governor prepares to lead New Jersey into its next chapter, the following ambitious but achievable policy actions would secure a resilient, equitable, and prosperous future. These recommendations draw from RPA’s Fourth Regional Plan and reflect decades of research on sustainable, competitive, and livable growth for the Garden State.



From tunnels to transit. New Jersey’s infrastructure underpins its

from tunnels to transit, from safety to sustainable transportation, an economy, mobility, and environmental future. Yet far too many people are stuck in traffic, waiting for unreliable buses or trains, or paying more for less. Building a more affordable, equitable, and economically competitive future starts with how we get around the most densely developed state in the nation. That means investing in public transit, prioritizing highway and bridge repairs over costly highway expansions, and making steady progress on the generational projects that can shift the state's long-term trajectory.

***** RPA RECOMMENDS

Build Gateway Now

Upgrade and modernize Newark Penn Station

Fund NJ TRANSIT

Appoint dynamic transportation leaders

Fix it first

Prioritize ZEV infrastructure and incentive programs

Support safe active transportation

New Jersey is in a housing crisis. RPA research shows that between 2000–2020, housing production declined 28% compared to the previous two decades, even as demand surged. This mismatch has driven up prices and reduced affordability, deepening statewide inequities. Local zoning barriers and fragmented policies continue to block growth in the very places people most need to live—especially near jobs and transit.

Jersey City exemplifies this growing strain. Despite a construction boom that added nearly 26,000 units between 2010 and 2022—triple the per capita rate of the surrounding metro region—housing demand has far outpaced supply. Jersey City rents have risen 50% since 2015, and 60% of households earning below the city’s median income are still cost-burdened. Projections show that by 2032, Jersey City could face a housing shortfall of 27,000 to 36,500 units, nearly a quarter of its entire housing stock. Additionally, we can’t just build our way out of this crisis. We need to revisit the kind of housing we build, where we build it, and who can afford to live there.

The next administration must act boldly to expand housing supply, improve affordability, and enable sustainable, inclusive growth in every New Jersey community.

..... RPA RECOMMENDS

Promote housing growth across the state

Uphold and strengthen the Mt. Laurel Doctrine

Leverage the State Development and Redevelopment Plan as a comprehensive framework to prioritize smart growth.

Encourage development with gap-financing programs

Address the regional impacts of local developments

New Jersey faces acute climate risks, from flooding and sea level rise to extreme heat and stronger storms. The next governor must lead a whole-of-government effort to resilience that protects people, infrastructure, and ecosystems alike.

Areas at high risk for future flooding and with potential for smart growth need forward-looking planning that supports development and protects infrastructure and communities through resilient design. Comprehensive risk assessments should guide strategic investments, and funding must align with both growth opportunities and adaptation needs, especially in vulnerable communities.

The next administration must act decisively to align land use, infrastructure, and environmental planning around climate risk.

***** RPA RECOMMENDS

Align land use planning with climate risk by prioritizing growth in safer areas and managing retreat from those at high risk

Designate the Meadowlands as a State Climate Preserve

Scale up green and blue infrastructure investments

Modernize zoning and building codes to reflect future climate conditions

Expand and strengthen the Blue Acres program

New Jersey has made real progress toward clean energy, but our infrastructure hasn't kept pace. Much of the state's electric grid was built for a different era and is struggling to support the demands of a modern, electrified economy. Without bold, coordinated action, New Jersey risks falling short of its climate goals and losing ground on energy reliability and economic competitiveness. From data centers to heat pumps to electric buses, the energy needs of the future are already here—and our systems must be ready to meet them.

The next administration must take decisive steps to modernize our energy system so that it is not only cleaner, but also more resilient, equitable, and capable of powering a thriving economy.

..... RPA RECOMMENDS

Upgrade the state's aging grid to meet 21st-century energy demands

Modernize transmission using advanced grid technologies

Make resilience a core investment priority

Scale up and streamline commercial rooftop solar and storage

Bolster the existing Community Solar Program

Embed energy planning into local land use

Recommit to offshore wind and provide a roadmap for advancement

Invest in infrastructure and finish the wind port

Strengthen the Board of Public Utilities

Understanding the feasibility of expanded nuclear

The success of any policy platform depends not just on vision, but on the ability to deliver through clear priorities, strong institutions, and coordinated action. These recommendations are grounded in that understanding. They are ambitious, but achievable. With bold leadership and a willingness to invest in the systems that sustain daily life, New Jersey can become a national model for growth and resilience.



LOCATION

New Jersey

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